

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Environmental Consulting English

Learner workbook

Work with realistic cases, develop your own response, and use the answer section after you have tried the tasks.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For environmental consultants, remediation managers, sustainability analysts, field scientists, permitting specialists, ESG teams, and environmental project managers.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Phase I and Phase II Site Assessments

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

02 Sampling Plans and Data Quality

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

03 Permitting and Agency Coordination

Clarify missing information before responding.

04 Remediation Options and Risk

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

05 Regulatory Compliance and Audits

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

06 Sustainability and ESG Reporting

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

07 Community and Stakeholder Meetings

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

08 Proposal, Scope, and Client Expectations

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one case and saying a response. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, conversation, writing, and revision.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

LESSON 01 / READ AND NOTICE

Phase I and Phase II Site Assessments

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

A site-assessment summary says no further questions remain, but one historical record has not been obtained.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

Phase I ESA - An environmental site assessment reviewing records and site information to identify relevant environmental concerns.

REC - Recognized environmental condition: a defined environmental-assessment term concerning hazardous substances or petroleum at a property.

Phase II - A further environmental investigation often involving sampling to assess concerns identified at a site.

due diligence - Structured review of facts, risks, obligations, and evidence before a transaction, onboarding, investment, or decision.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Improve this sentence: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 01 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change definitely caused the delay.
 - B. The change may have contributed to the delay.
 - C. The change must have caused the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. In this pilot, the observed result was ...
 - B. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...
 - C. Across the service, the observed result was ...

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 02 / READ AND NOTICE

Sampling Plans and Data Quality

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

SITUATION

A sample record omits a transfer signature. The laboratory result is available, but the chain-of-custody record needs review.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

sampling plan - A plan specifying what will be sampled, where, when, and by which method.

chain of custody - A documented record of who handled a sample or item and when it changed hands.

detection limit - The lowest amount or concentration reliably distinguished from absence under a specified method.

QA/QC - Quality assurance and quality control: processes for establishing quality and checking specific results.

3. Notice the language

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

Improve this sentence: Please revert soonest with the necessary.

LESSON 02 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask for an actionable next step

4. Check the language

1. What does 'Please send it by Thursday' normally mean?
 - A. Send it no later than Thursday.
 - B. Send it on Thursday, but not earlier.
 - C. Keep sending it regularly until Thursday.
2. Which request gives the recipient enough detail to act?
 - A. Could you confirm that the review is important?
 - B. Could you confirm that you received my earlier message?
 - C. Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 03 / READ AND NOTICE

Permitting and Agency Coordination

Clarify missing information before responding.

SITUATION

An agency comment requests additional modeling but does not specify which scenario the team believes is missing.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

permit - Official permission for an activity under specified requirements.

agency comment - A question, observation, or requested change from a reviewing public agency.

public notice - A formal announcement made available to the public about an action or process.

modeling - Creating a representation of a system or outcome using stated relationships and assumptions.

3. Notice the language

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Improve this sentence: Could you explain what does this mean?

LESSON 03 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Ask a precise question

4. Check the language

1. Which indirect question has the usual word order?
 - A. Could you confirm when does the review start?
 - B. Could you confirm when starts the review?
 - C. Could you confirm when the review starts?
2. Someone says the report is 'ready.' Which question best clarifies its approval status?
 - A. Who will present the report at the meeting?
 - B. Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?
 - C. Can you send the report to me this afternoon?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 04 / READ AND NOTICE

Remediation Options and Risk

Compare options using the same criteria and state the tradeoff.

SITUATION

Two remediation options have different implementation times and monitoring needs. A client asks which is simply "best."

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

remediation - Work to correct a problem or reduce its effects; in environmental work, addressing contamination.

exposure pathway - The route by which a contaminant can reach a person or other receptor.

cap - A covering used in some remediation approaches to limit contact with contaminated material.

long-term monitoring - Repeated observation or measurement over an extended period to track conditions.

3. Notice the language

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Improve this sentence: This option is more better.

LESSON 04 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Explain a fair comparison

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence expresses a clear contrast?
 - A. Option A is faster, so option B costs less.
 - B. Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.
 - C. Option A is faster because option B costs less.
2. A rate increases from 6% to 7%. What is the absolute difference?
 - A. An increase of one percentage point.
 - B. An increase of one percent relative to the original rate.
 - C. An increase of seven percentage points.

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You favor one option but have not checked whether the scope is comparable. Ask about one difference, then explain the tradeoff you are willing to accept.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 05 / READ AND NOTICE

Regulatory Compliance and Audits

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

SITUATION

A compliance review has six findings. Four have documented corrective actions; two still lack an assigned owner.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

compliance audit - An examination of evidence against applicable rules or organizational requirements.

corrective action - Action taken to fix a current problem and prevent recurrence.

recordkeeping - Creating, organizing, maintaining, and retaining required records.

inspection - An examination of an item or condition against relevant requirements.

3. Notice the language

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Improve this sentence: Everything is progressing well.

LESSON 05 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Give a useful status update

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence says a review is finished?
 - A. The team has completed the review.
 - B. The team is completing the review.
 - C. The team plans to complete the review.
2. Which update distinguishes a plan from a confirmed fact?
 - A. Delivery is confirmed for Friday because we planned it.
 - B. The delivery plan proves that arrival will be Friday.
 - C. Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it.

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 06 / READ AND NOTICE

Sustainability and ESG Reporting

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

SITUATION

A sustainability draft says the company is carbon neutral, but the supporting calculation covers only selected operations.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

ESG - Environmental, social, and governance factors considered in organizational reporting or decisions.

Scope 1 - Direct greenhouse-gas emissions from sources owned or controlled by the reporting organization under the chosen framework.

Scope 2 - Indirect greenhouse-gas emissions from generating purchased or acquired energy used by the reporting organization.

Scope 3 - Other indirect greenhouse-gas emissions in an organization's value chain under the relevant reporting framework.

carbon neutral - A claim about balancing specified carbon emissions with removals or offsets within a stated boundary and period.

3. Notice the language

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Improve this sentence: The pilot proves this will work everywhere.

LESSON 06 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Match certainty to evidence

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence preserves uncertainty about an unconfirmed cause?
 - A. The change must have caused the delay.
 - B. The change definitely caused the delay.
 - C. The change may have contributed to the delay.
2. A result comes from a small pilot in one location. Which phrase accurately limits the claim?
 - A. Across the service, the observed result was ...
 - B. In this pilot, the observed result was ...
 - C. In similar locations, we can now expect the same result ...

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 07 / READ AND NOTICE

Community and Stakeholder Meetings

Explain a useful distinction in plain English.

SITUATION

Residents ask whether a preliminary result proves that an entire area is safe. Sampling covered only specified locations and conditions.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

stakeholder - Person or group with an interest, risk, authority, or dependency in the work.

plume - An area of contamination spreading through a medium such as groundwater or air.

exposure - The extent to which people, assets, or operations are subject to a hazard or potential loss.

risk communication - Explaining a risk, its evidence, uncertainty, and relevant response to an audience.

3. Notice the language

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Improve this sentence: We need to operationalize the implementation.

LESSON 07 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Make a complex point clear

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence explains 'backlog' rather than repeating it?
 - A. The backlog is the maximum work the team can finish in a period.
 - B. The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.
 - C. The backlog is the work completed during the last period.
2. Which follow-up best checks whether your explanation was clear?
 - A. How would you describe the next step in your own words?
 - B. Would you like me to repeat the explanation?
 - C. Was the explanation detailed enough for you?

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

LESSON 08 / READ AND NOTICE

Proposal, Scope, and Client Expectations

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit.

SITUATION

A client requests additional sampling outside the agreed scope. The team has not assessed the extra time and cost.

1. Understand the situation

Identify two confirmed facts, one missing detail, and the person who needs your response. Do not fill gaps with invented facts.

2. Find the words

scope - Defined boundary of work, responsibility, deliverables, assumptions, and exclusions.

assumption - Something treated as true for planning or reasoning, though it may need verification.

deliverable - A specified item of work to be provided to a customer or project recipient.

change order - A documented modification to agreed construction work, often affecting price or time.

3. Notice the language

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Improve this sentence: If you will approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

LESSON 08 / PRACTICE AND PRODUCE

Offer a workable tradeoff

4. Check the language

1. Which sentence presents a normal future condition clearly?
 - A. If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.
 - B. If the scope will change, we will review the schedule.
 - C. If the scope changes, we reviewed the schedule.
2. Which response negotiates a new request without silently promising extra work?
 - A. We have included it, although its scope has not been reviewed.
 - B. We guarantee the original date without assessing the addition.
 - C. We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.

5. Say it

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

6. Write it

Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Check: facts accurate | meaning clear | tone appropriate | next action or question explicit

After revising your response: open the AI extension for feedback on your own draft.

Answer workshop

Try the tasks first. The model is one acceptable response, not a script to memorize. Your written version needs a subject line, an opening, and appropriate context. Assess it using the four criteria at the end.

01 | Phase I and Phase II Site Assessments

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: B - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

B: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

C: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

Check 2: A - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

B: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

C: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

Model response: The review is incomplete because that historical record is missing. I'll identify the information gap and its significance for the assessment rather than imply that all relevant questions have been resolved.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

02 | Sampling Plans and Data Quality

Editing example: Could you send the missing document and confirm when it will be available?

The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Check 1: A - Send it no later than Thursday.

A: 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.

B: "By Thursday" permits earlier delivery; it is not restricted to that day.

C: This interprets a deadline as a continuing activity, which would use "until".

Check 2: C - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review?

A: This checks importance rather than identifying the needed document version.

B: This checks receipt, not which version is required for the review.

C: The requested action and information are explicit.

Model response: Could the responsible team review the missing transfer record and document the resolution? I'll flag the gap in the data-quality discussion instead of treating the paperwork as complete.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

03 | Permitting and Agency Coordination

Editing example: Could you explain what this means?

After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Check 1: C - Could you confirm when the review starts?

A: Remove 'does' and use statement word order after 'confirm'.

B: Place the subject 'the review' before 'starts'.

C: The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".

Check 2: B - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review?

A: This asks about the presenter, not the report's approval status.

B: This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

C: This asks about delivery timing, not whether approval has happened.

Model response: Could we confirm which scenario and supporting information the comment refers to? I'll draft a focused clarification question and identify our proposed response for review.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

04 | Remediation Options and Risk

Editing example: This option is better on cost, but slower to deliver.

'Better' already has comparative meaning, so it does not need 'more'. Naming the criterion and tradeoff makes the comparison useful.

Check 1: B - Option A is faster, whereas option B costs less.

A: 'So' implies one fact causes the other.

B: 'Whereas' marks a contrast between two options.

C: 'Because' claims a causal connection that is not given.

Check 2: A - An increase of one percentage point.

A: Subtracting 6% from 7% gives one percentage point. The relative increase is about 16.7%.

B: A one-percent relative increase on 6% would be 6.06%, not 7%.

C: The new rate is 7%; the difference between the rates is one percentage point.

Model response: The options address the problem in different ways and have different monitoring needs. Let's compare them against the agreed objectives and site conditions before recommending a preferred approach.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

05 | Regulatory Compliance and Audits

Editing example: Three checks are complete; two remain open and are being reviewed.

The revision gives observable progress. A positive label alone does not tell the reader what is complete or still needed.

Check 1: A - The team has completed the review.

A: 'Has completed' states that the action is finished.

B: 'Is completing' presents the work as in progress.

C: 'Plans to complete' describes an intention, not completion.

Check 2: C - Delivery is planned for Friday; the carrier has not confirmed it.

A: A plan does not establish carrier confirmation.

B: A plan cannot prove a future arrival time.

C: This explicitly labels the date as planned and identifies the missing confirmation.

Model response: Four findings have documented actions. Two still need owners and target dates. I'll make those open decisions visible in the review update and distinguish planned actions from completed ones.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

06 | Sustainability and ESG Reporting

Editing example: The pilot worked in the tested setting; performance elsewhere remains untested.

The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Check 1: C - The change may have contributed to the delay.

A: 'Must have' expresses a strong inference that the evidence may not support.

B: 'Definitely' presents the cause as certain.

C: 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

Check 2: B - In this pilot, the observed result was ...

A: A pilot in one location does not establish a service-wide observation.

B: This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

C: Similarity alone does not establish that the result will transfer.

Model response: The calculation does not yet support that broad claim. I'll state the included operations and reporting boundary clearly, then route the proposed wording for the appropriate review.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

07 | Community and Stakeholder Meetings

Editing example: We need to put the plan into practice.

The revised sentence names the action in familiar words. Specialist vocabulary is useful when it adds precision, but repeating abstract nouns can hide the meaning.

Check 1: B - The backlog is the work still waiting to be completed.

A: This describes capacity, not the work waiting to be completed.

B: This gives the meaning in familiar words.

C: Completed work is different from work still waiting.

Check 2: A - How would you describe the next step in your own words?

A: An open request lets the listener show their understanding.

B: Offering repetition may help, but it does not show how the listener understood the next step.

C: This invites an opinion on detail, not a demonstration of understanding.

Model response: The result describes the sampled locations and conditions. It does not answer every question about the wider area. We should explain the findings, their limits, and the next planned information step clearly.

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

08 | Proposal, Scope, and Client Expectations

Editing example: If you approve the scope, we can assess the schedule.

For an ordinary future condition, the "if" clause uses present tense. The other clause can express the future consequence or possibility.

Check 1: A - If the scope changes, we will review the schedule.

A: The "if" clause uses present tense; the main clause states the future response.

B: For this ordinary future condition, use present simple in the "if" clause.

C: "Reviewed" places the response in the past instead of expressing the future response.

Check 2: C - We can assess the addition and explain its effect on the agreed scope.

A: It treats unreviewed work as already included.

B: It promises an outcome without examining the consequences.

C: This offers a useful next step while keeping the approval and scope question open.

Model response: We can assess the additional sampling as a scope change. Could we confirm the question it needs to answer, then provide the time and cost implications before agreeing to the work?

Case check: underline the confirmed information and circle a limitation, question, or next step in the response.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

GHG Protocol: corporate standard

<https://ghgprotocol.org/corporate-standard>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Practice grammar in context

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Environmental Consulting English

Professional audience: environmental consultants, remediation managers, sustainability analysts, field scientists, permitting specialists, ESG teams, and environmental project managers

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Phase I and Phase II Site Assessments

Original fictional case: A site-assessment summary says no further questions remain, but one historical record has not been obtained.

Language workshop: Match certainty to evidence

Communication goal: Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

Language guidance: Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): The available evidence shows ... / This may indicate ..., but ... / We have not yet established whether ...

Vocabulary: Phase I ESA: An environmental site assessment reviewing records and site information to identify relevant environmental concerns. / REC: Recognized environmental condition: a defined environmental-assessment term concerning hazardous substances or petroleum at a property. / Phase II: A further environmental investigation often involving sampling to assess concerns identified at a site. / due diligence: Structured review of facts, risks, obligations, and evidence before a transaction, onboarding,

investment, or decision.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The review is incomplete because that historical record is missing. I'll identify the information gap and its significance for the assessment rather than imply that all relevant questions have been resolved.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Grammar that changes the meaning

1. For a lesson, use its language workshop as the focus. For a dialogue, quote one actual sentence and select one useful grammar feature from it, such as question word order, tense, modality, conditionals or clause linking. Explain in no more than 90 words how this feature helps the speakers do their work. Keep the grammar target narrow.
2. Give two short contrasting sentences using this workplace context. Explain the difference in time, certainty, condition or politeness. Label invented examples and preserve the distinction between possible, planned and confirmed events. Describe context-dependent choices as choices, not universal rules.
3. Give me one editing or sentence-building task using a known case fact. Do not copy the supplied editing example or reveal its answer. Ask me to explain my intended meaning. Stop and wait.
4. After I answer, quote my wording, identify at most two issues, and give a brief explanation and one hint. Ask me to revise before offering a full corrected version. Then accept any accurate, natural alternative that serves the purpose.
5. Continue with two new tasks, one at a time: first guided, then an original response without a sentence frame. End with a two-sentence workplace message using the target feature and a compact self-check. Do not replace this sequence with a worksheet and answer key.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Get feedback on a draft

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: The review is incomplete because that historical record is missing. I'll identify the information gap and its significance for the assessment rather than imply that all relevant questions have been resolved.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Coach my workplace writing

1. Ask me to paste my own fictional or anonymized draft and identify its reader and purpose. If the reference gives a writing task, mention that task as the default. If it is a dialogue, suggest a brief follow-up message that records its outcome and open questions. Stop and wait. Do not write the message for me first.
2. Once I supply the draft, check it against the reference. If an ambiguity changes the meaning, ask one focused question before rewriting. Do not assume that the draft is correct evidence for a new deadline, approval, diagnosis, cost or commitment.
3. Give feedback in three parts: one effective phrase with a reason; up to three priority improvements, quoting my words; and one short revision task for me. Prioritize incorrect facts or unclear action before minor grammar. For each language correction, explain why it matters to this reader. Label optional stylistic alternatives separately and preserve my level of certainty and intended politeness.
4. Stop and wait for my revision. Then compare the two attempts, identify an improvement and offer one edited version that preserves my voice and purpose. Keep the requested length; if none is specified, use 70-110 words. Explain any meaningful change rather than silently making the message stronger or more certain.
5. Close with one phrase worth reusing and a short transfer task for a different fictional reader. Wait for my attempt before providing another model.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level